

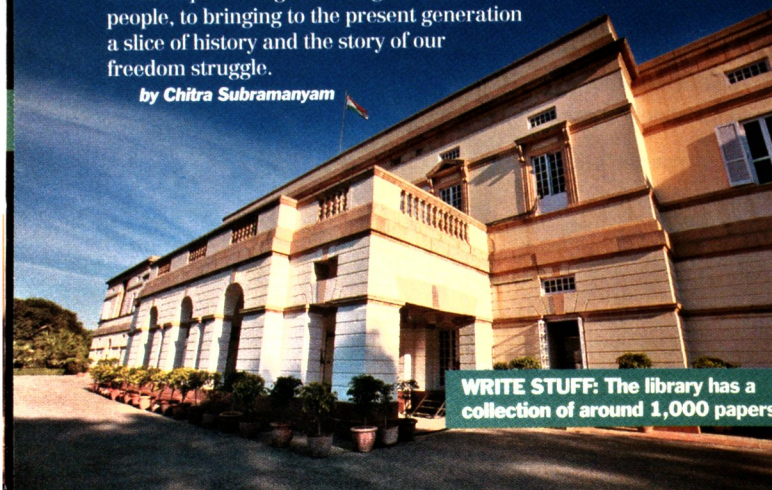
NEHRU MEMORIAL MUSEUM AND LIBRARY, DELHI TRYST WITH THE PAST

From the time its gates open every morning, 7,000 visitors bustle through what used to be Jawaharlal Nehru's home as prime minister. They shuffle through the rooms, picnic in the lawns and walk on the 44.74 acre of the Teen Murti Bhavan. But in a corner, unnoticed by the tourists is a sprawling building, home to India's colonial and post-colonial history. Only a privileged few breathe this rarefied air. They are the academics, the researchers who spend their time analysing our past. Just like Nehru Memorial Museum and Library Director Mridula Mukherjee who visited the library for research in 1971. It used to be in the house, she remembers, "and the canteen was a little shack with a tin roof".

Since then, the library has evolved, as has its collection of private and public papers. Whether it is the documents belonging to Walchand Hirachand, the magnate who started the first Swadeshi shipping company, bird man Salim Ali, or Shekhar Singh's original letters to Medha Patkar on the Chipko and Narmada movements, they all are here. "People have spent a year on collections so vast," says Mukherjee. The collections now number 1,000. "There was a time when people had to be persuaded to donate their papers. Now we hardly have the option of asking," Mukherjee says. And it shows. The library door opens quietly with an unnoticeable swish. Silence hangs in the air; the only sound, if at all, is that of shuffling pages.

On the first floor, occasional whirring catches one off-guard. It's a sound least expected. Students and researchers sit in a dimly lit room, in front of microfiche machines, scanning newspapers, reading headlines of a time long gone. They are in English and different Indian languages. *The Dawn*, when it used to be based in Delhi in 1942, or the *Capital* from 1889, the *Central Hindu College* magazine from the early 1900s or the *Civil and Military Gazette* from 1877. "Sometimes, the only surviving place, where these newspapers can be found, is the library," says Mukherjee. Now, an attempt is being made to put these documents online, to protect the crumbling paper and allow easy storage. A process of revamping and modernising the museum is also the order of the day. And now, an attempt is being made to give back to the people, to bringing to the present generation a slice of history and the story of our freedom struggle.

by Chitra Subramanyam



WRITE STUFF: The library has a collection of around 1,000 papers

MANDAR DEODHAR



NCPA, MUMBAI

THE CENTRE STAGE

Eight acres of land worth Rs 20 billion. Nariman Point, the southern-most tip of Mumbai overlooking the sea, is the stuff that real estate dreams are made of. But to the culturally inclined in Mumbai, the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) represents a gated community that comes alive in its five all-sized auditoriums. The dream of late Jamshed J. Bhabha, younger brother of Homi Bhabha and a member of the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research's management council, the idea of a space to promote culture was conceptualised in the early 1960s. It was, however, not until 1966 that the centre was registered as the National Institute of Performing Arts and later rechristened. And even then, it wasn't this sprawling space that hosted performances. "The first few plays were held at renowned lawyer Bhulabhai Desai's house that had a theatre," says Khusrro Suntook, vice-chairman, NCPA.

To the relief of all theatre lovers, how-

MAN'S SALON